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The right regains its rhythm as NDA breaks out of the post-2004 defeatism and shows signs of revival. UPA stagnates even as its leader hovers over the prime minister. L.K. Advani gains in popularity but Atal Bihari Vajpayee still rules the hearts. An impatient nation calls for change.



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movers of Indian politics. Manmohan is not. And here lies the biggest challenge for Sonia, who hovers over her dutiful prime minister.

She may well take note that there is no half leader in politics. The division of labour between the party president and the prime minister—well, the church and the state—is not working. Those who swear by her also want her to be more visible and accessible. A growing majority of Indians think she is more powerful than the prime minister. The maximum leader is expected to take maximum responsibility. Since her resignation from the National Advisory Council in 2006, she has not taken any active initiative in making UPA much more aggressive. As the absolute leader of her party, she alone is answerable as the coalition she leads slides or stagnates. Leaders like Mayawati have already taken away the traditional Congress vote banks.

The beneficiary of UPA's passivity is NDA, which, after a long period of hibernation, is an alliance that can deliver. Twelve months ago, only 24 per cent of the voters felt that BJP was the party most suited for solving India's problems. With the current rating at 28 per cent, it has restored its credibility as a party of governance. For the first time, substantial percentage of OBCs, MBCs and SC/ST voters have chosen BJP. The intimation is ominous: the so-called rainbow coalition of castes and communities created by Congress and its allies is crumbling. In this gathering bleakness, there is a glimmer of hope: in the percentage of votes, the ruling coalition is still ahead of the NDA—marginally. And Rahul Gandhi, the crown prince, gets a big nod of approval.

Does it mean that Sonia can afford to be what she is: a Mrs G without the original's flair for playing with the mass mind? She can't forever remain a leader in the making, that too despite the entire party investing its future in the dynasty. As the right regains its rhythm after Narendra Modi's experiment with ideas of development and ideology of renewal and Advani's reinvention of himself, India's GOP needs a new script from its leader. An impatient India has spoken its mind. ■